

KEY FIGURE

GHENGHIS KHAN
1162–1227

Originally named Temujin, the founder of the Mongol Empire took the title Genghis Khan after uniting the steppe tribes in 1206. By the time of his death, his horsemen had campaigned as far west as the Black Sea coast and begun the conquest of China.



▲ Genghis Khan inspired the steppe horsemen with his ambition to create a universal empire.

▼ TIMUR

A Turco-Mongol warrior from Uzbekistan, Timur defeated the Mongol Golden Horde, the Egyptian Mamluks, and the Ottoman Turks. Before he died in 1405, he was planning an invasion of China.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

EAST ASIAN WARFARE

Three distinct approaches to weapons and warfare evolved in medieval East Asia. While steppe tribesmen depended upon horses and the compound bow, and China combined advanced technology with mass peasant armies, the Japanese, developed the idiosyncratic, highly ritualized fighting style of the samurai warrior.

Under the dynasties of the Tang (618–907 CE) and the Song (960–1279), China was the world leader in technological innovation. However, defending its long frontier from bow-armed nomadic horsemen often overwhelmed the country's military resources.

The Song fielded large armies of conscripted foot soldiers. Although most were equipped with basic staff weapons, such as the halberd, they also used an impressive array of crossbows, ranging from simple, hand-held bows to large, lever-operated repeating crossbows capable of emptying a 10-bolt magazine in under 20 seconds. By the 13th century, the Song armies also had primitive gunpowder weapons, although these had only a marginal impact.

INVADING FORCES

Despite its technological and numerical advantages, China was often invaded by steppe peoples. In the 12th century, the Song lost control of northern China to federations of steppe tribes – first the Jurchen, and then the Mongols. The vulnerability of China was partly due to its military failings – primarily the lack of cavalry – but it also reflected the remarkable effectiveness of the steppe warriors. When a leader united them in sufficiently large numbers, the steppe tribes' ability to campaign over long distances and their deadly efficiency in battle enabled them to achieve wide-ranging conquests; they campaigned as far west as Hungary and Poland. Between the 1380s and 1405, Timur – who claimed descent from Genghis Khan – campaigned victoriously from Delhi, in India, to Ankara, in Turkey. The Song dynasty retained control of southern China by exploiting its naval strength on the Yangtze River, which formed a barrier against the north. The permanent Song navy, founded in 1132, deployed a remarkable variety of vessels, including multi-deck "tower ships" that were armed with various kinds of catapult. Some warships were propelled by human-powered paddle wheels; others were fast-moving, oared galleys. The Song

could not hold out against the Mongol forces of Kublai Khan, however, who created his own fleet to conquer southern China in 1279, and later sailed to Japan and Java, a tradition continued by the next native Chinese dynasty, the Ming (1368–1644). From 1405 to 1433, the eunuch admiral Zheng He led the Ming fleet to East Africa. But he soon turned his attention to defending the steppe frontier, diverting resources to build the Great Wall.

Meanwhile, a distinctive military culture had developed in Japan. Samurai warriors emerged in the 10th century as soldiers in the service of the Japanese emperors, and over time they formed

